

Your Shopping Checklist

CD-Writer

- ✓ Make sure that the drive has a high spin speed and fast access times. Access time is more important if you need to read non-sequential data such as a game.
- ✓ Does it support over burning?
- ✓ Does it support Multi-Session and Incremental Packet Writing?
- ✓ Does it support Raw writing?
- ✓ Does it include a CD burning software?

DVD-ROM Drive

- ✓ A DVD-ROM drive on the other hand should be able to read dual-sided DVD media
- ✓ Does it include DVD playback software?

Common

- ✓ Can the drive's firmware be upgraded for future support?
- ✓ Are drivers for operating systems like DOS and Win 3.x included?
- ✓ Are the audio and IDE cables included?
- ✓ Does it have at least a one-year warranty?

Our Best Performance Award winner was the Iomega CDRW55296INT-B CD-Writer. Also worthy of mention are the Samsung CD-Writers—they were the most feature-packed Writers and came complete with the requisite cables, software and manuals.

The LG 8320B, a 32x CD-Writer, had the highest overall score, even though it did not win in terms of pure performance. It wins our Best Value Award.

Looking onto our other match up between the DVD-ROM drives, we found that the overall as well as the Best Performance Award winner was the Benq DVP-1648A—it offered the best of performance at a reasonable price of Rs 2,995.

The LITEON LTD-165H drive, which wasn't far behind in any of the tests, is even cheaper than Benq and is an easy winner of our Best Value Award. The Pioneer drive, which was the winner in our last comparison, stood last here. This is really shocking, as the performance of the drive can't drop so much. Either Pioneer is not serious with their DVD-ROM business or the competition is working overtime to make their product the best in the world.

Decision Maker			
You want	To back up a lot of data	An excellent movie experience	Just a decent optical drive you can upgrade to
You need	A fast and reliable CD-Writer	A DVD-ROM drive of good quality	A cheap CD-Writer or a DVD drive
Look for	A 32x or faster CD-Writer, with 2 MB buffer	A 16x DVD-ROM drive with 512 KB buffer	Any drive which can read data at a speed of 48x
The models	LG 8320B or Iomega CDRW55296INT-B	Benq DVP-1648A or LITEON LTD-165H	LITEON LTD-165H or Krypton BCE-4012M
Price range	Rs 3,400 to Rs 6,500	Rs 2,650 to Rs 2,995	Rs 2,650 to Rs 3,075

The winners!

Iomega CDRW55296INT-B CD-Writer: Iomega's CD-Writer came bundled with Nero 5.5.9.2c, which is not all that old a version. This drive includes a 2 MB buffer. This would appear to be rather less for a 48x CD-Writer, but despite this, the Writer logged the best performance scores in our tests.

The writer includes SMARTBURN burnproof technology to ensure that there are no errors during the write process. Though it is rather expensive at Rs 6,500, it delivers when it comes to performance.



This 48x Iomega CD-Writer can burn a 700 MB CD in under 4 minutes

LG 8320B CD-Writer: If you are looking for the best combination of price and performance, go for the LG 8320B. This CD-Writer is not only inexpensive but is also feature rich, with a decent performance to boot. Though it is a 32x drive, it has an 8 MB buffer which is an attractive plus. The Writer incorporates Superlink burnproof technology to eliminate CD wastage even on a slower machine. The Writer comes with a one-year warranty and is supported by a vast network of service centres spread across many cities.



The LG 8320B offers an 8 MB buffer for error free burning

Benq DVP-1648A DVD-ROM Drive: The Benq DVP-1648A DVD-ROM drive gave the best results across the board. The drive had a 512 KB cache to enable an error free movie experience. The drive is good if one is going to use it more as a CD-ROM drive as its transfer rate is quite decent. The best part is that the drive is so competitively priced that the competition will be forced to re-work their pricing policy to compete with Benq.



The Benq DVP-1648A offered outstanding performance in all our tests

LITEON LTD-165H DVD-ROM Drive: LITEON LTD165H DVD-ROM comes at a price that will be a sure attraction for many—it is available for only Rs 2,650. The drive has 512 KB cache and comes bundled with PowerDVD 4.0 DVD playback software. It also serves as an excellent substitute for a CD-ROM drive thanks to its fast data transfer rate. Overall, it offers a good blend of performance, features and price and is an easy winner of our Best Value Award.



The LITEON LTD-165H : great performance at a great price

ALIASGAR PARDAWALA and AHMED SHAIKH